TCS iON AI Hackathon
Student guide

Everything you do on the hackathon platform, screen by screen — from signing in to submitting your prototype.

Time	Steps	You need
2 hours	**7, shown at the top of every screen**	**Your event code and student ID**

The pictures use a practice event (`PRACTICE-2026`) with made-up challenges and sample answers about a canteen queue. Your event code, themes, challenges and AI results will be different.

Version 1.0 · 30 September 2026

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Before you start

- [ ] **A laptop or desktop with Chrome or Edge**
  The platform opens on a phone too, but building a prototype needs a bigger screen. Charge the battery and check your internet before you begin.
- [ ] **Your event code and student ID**
  Your coordinator gives you both. Your student ID is the one on iON.
- [ ] **Your own account on a building tool**
  Google AI Studio, Lovable or Bolt.new. Sign up before the event with your personal email or Google account — it saves time on the day. Any other tool you already know is fine too.
- [ ] **Two hours, start to finish**
  The platform closes at the event's end time. After that you can't sign in or change anything, so submit before the end.
- [ ] **A microphone, if you want one**
  Only if you would rather speak your answers than type them.

Use only your own details

Sign in with your own student ID and build with your own accounts. Don't share your ID or your passwords.

Your 2 hours at a glance

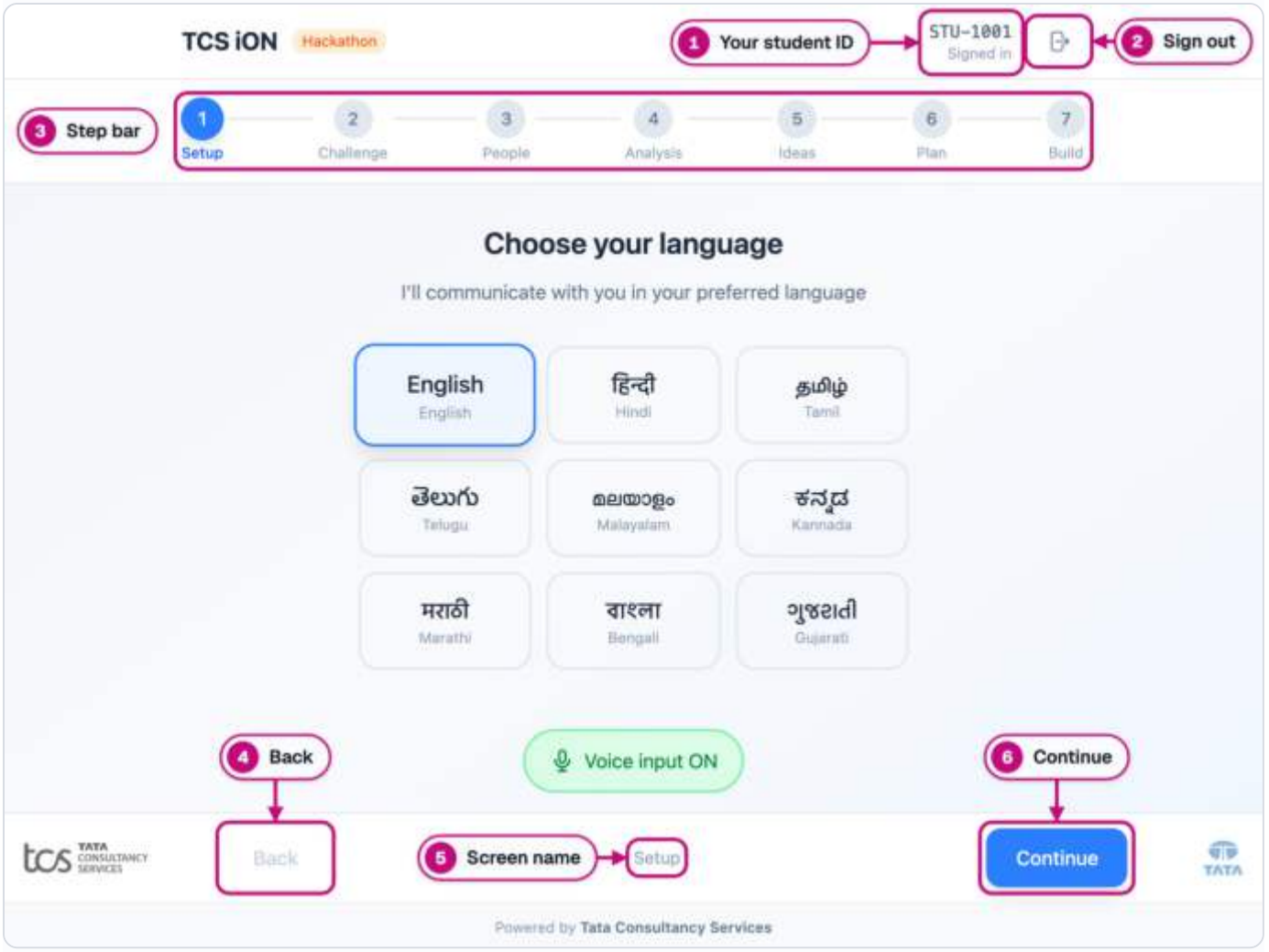
A suggested pace. Go faster where you can, and keep the last 10 minutes for uploading.

Time	What you do	Where
0:00–0:10	Sign in, choose your language, pick a theme and a challenge	Steps 1–2
0:10–0:30	Describe the people and their problems, then pick one pain point	Step 3
0:30–0:45	Read the root cause, rate three ideas and choose one	Steps 4–5
0:45–1:00	Confirm your idea, choose features, generate and download your build plan	Step 6
1:00–1:50	Build your prototype in an AI tool	Step 7
1:50–2:00	Upload screenshots or a video and press **Submit**	Step 7

Find your way around the screen

After you sign in, every screen has the same frame. Learn it once.

The frame around every screen



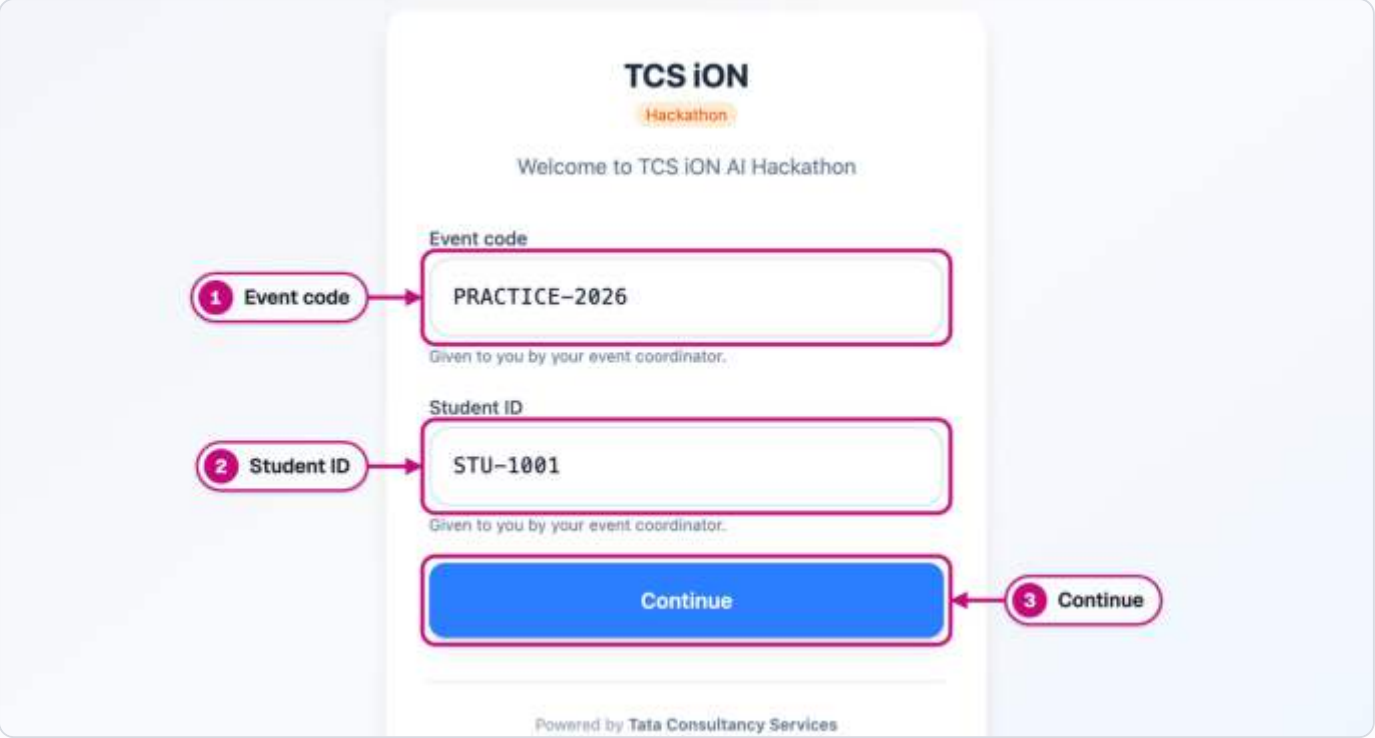
1. **Your student ID** — Shows who is signed in.
2. **Sign out** — Signs you out. Your work stays saved, and you can sign in again.
3. **Step bar** — The seven steps. A green tick means done; the blue circle is where you are.
4. **Back** — Goes to the previous screen. Your answers stay.
5. **Screen name** — The step and the screen you are on, for example **People · Who**. This guide uses the same names.
6. **Continue** — Moves you forward. It stays grey until you have answered the screen.

Start

Sign in

Open the link your coordinator shares. The page says **Welcome to TCS iON AI Hackathon**.

The sign-in page

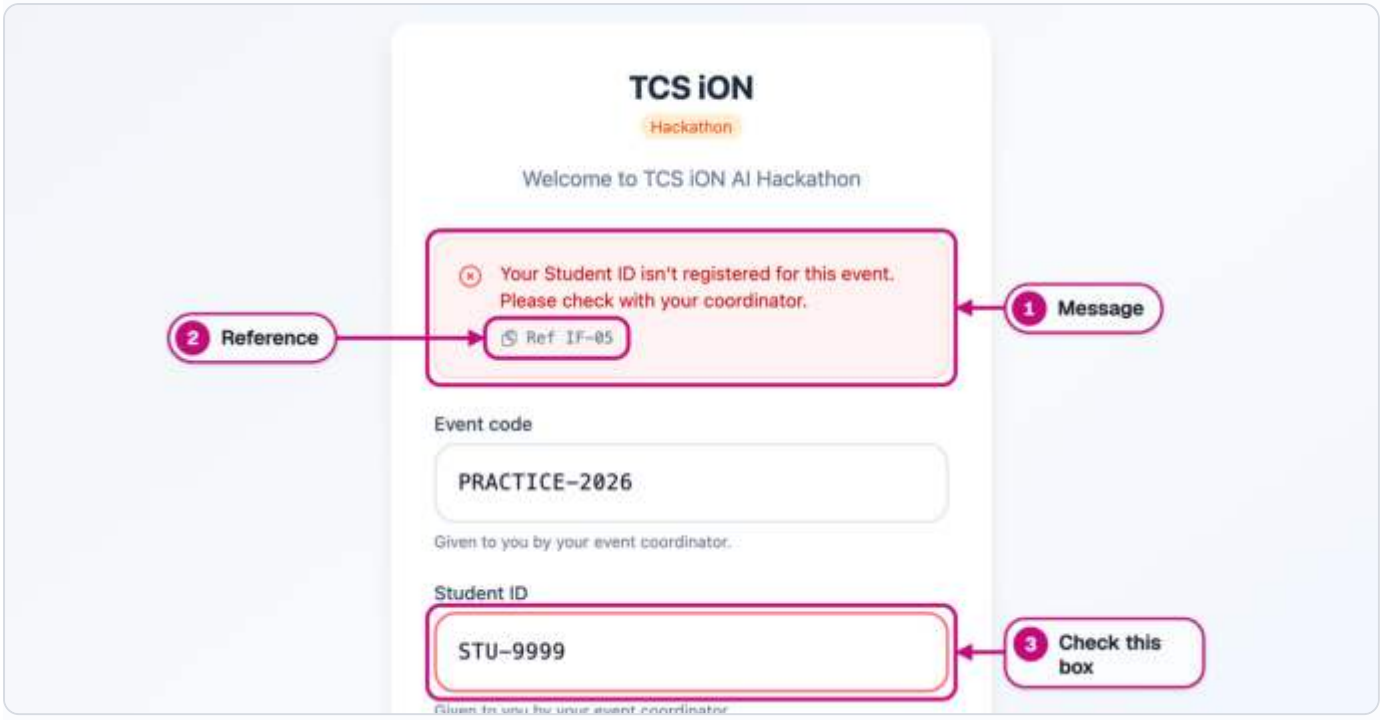


1. **Event code** — Type the event code, for example `PRACTICE-2026`. Capital or small letters both work.
2. **Student ID** — Type your student ID exactly as it appears on iON — no spaces, and keep any zeros at the start.
3. **Continue** — Signs you in and opens Step 1.

Signed in before?

You carry on from where you stopped. If you already submitted, you see your **Congratulations** screen again.

When sign-in doesn’t work



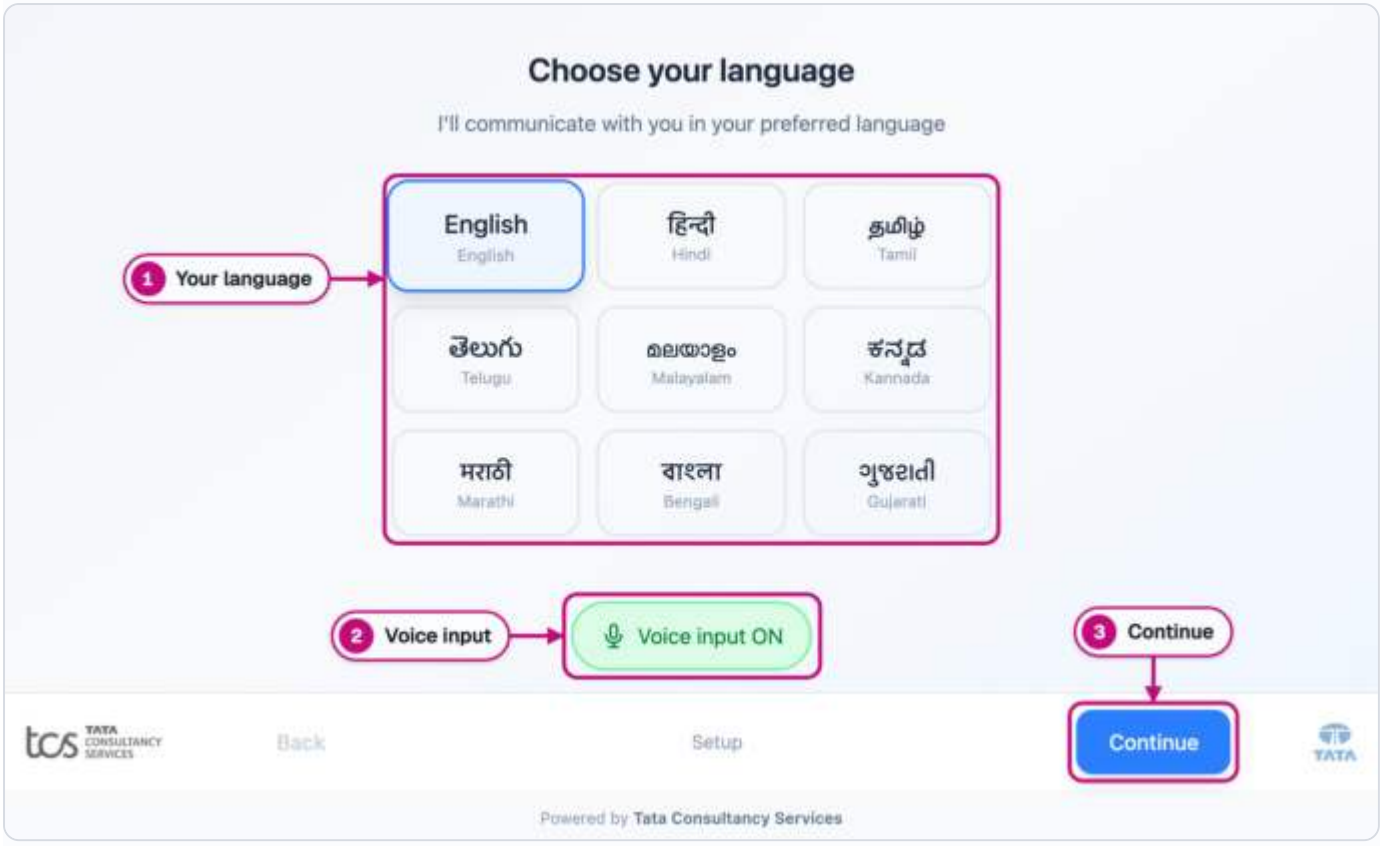
1. **Message** — Says what went wrong and what to do.
2. **Reference** — A reference such as `IF-05`. Give this to your coordinator — press it to copy it.
3. **Check this box** — The box with the problem is outlined in red.

Every sign-in message is listed in **If something goes wrong** at the end of this guide.

Step 1 of 7 · Setup

Choose your language

Setup



1. **Your language** — Pick one of nine: English, Hindi, Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam, Kannada, Marathi, Bengali or Gujarati.
2. **Voice input** — Leave it **ON** to speak your answers instead of typing. Press it to turn voice off.
3. **Continue** — Opens Step 2.

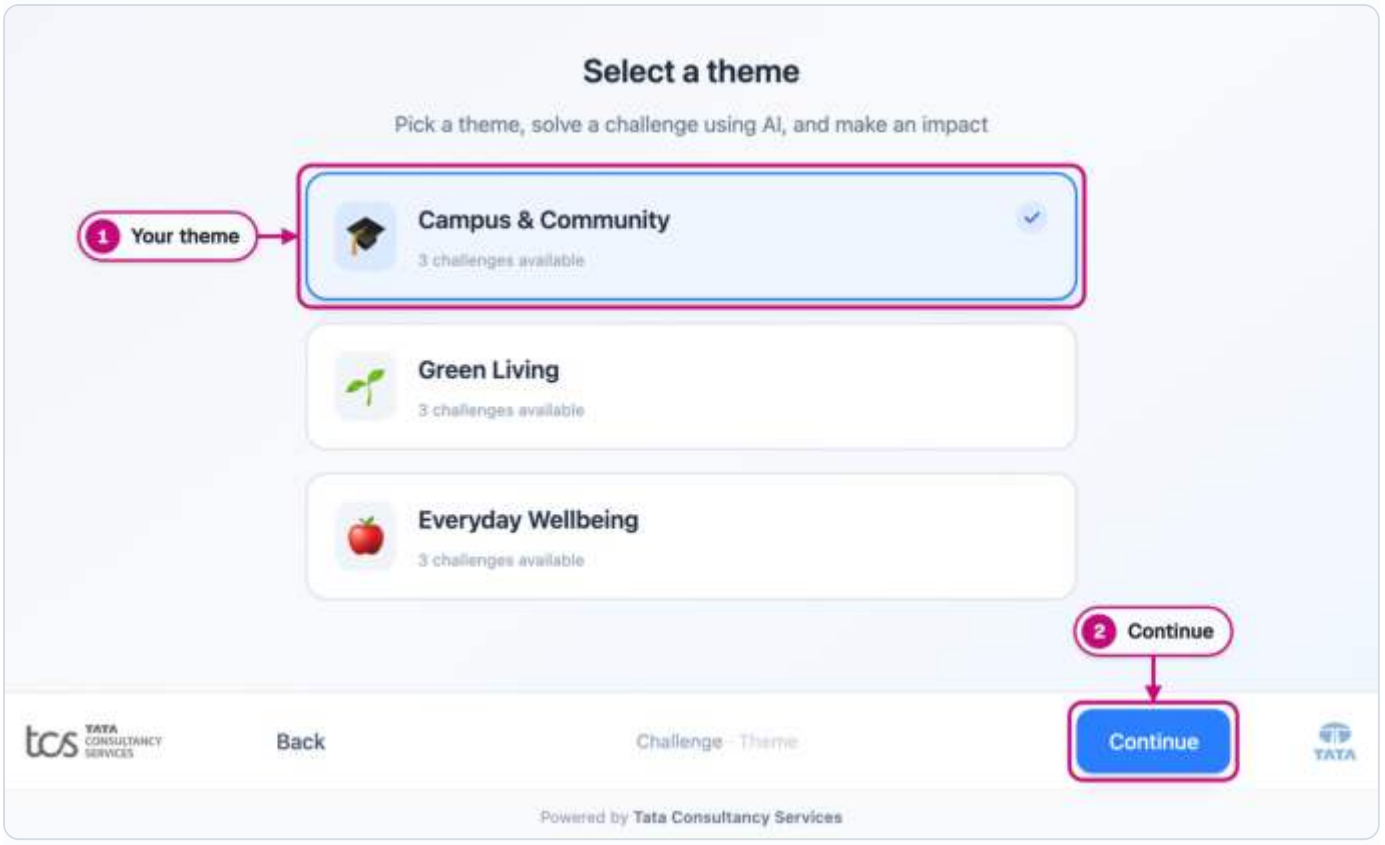
Choose carefully

Your language, theme, challenge and first answers lock during Step 3. After that you can read them but not change them.

Pick a theme and a challenge

Challenge · Theme

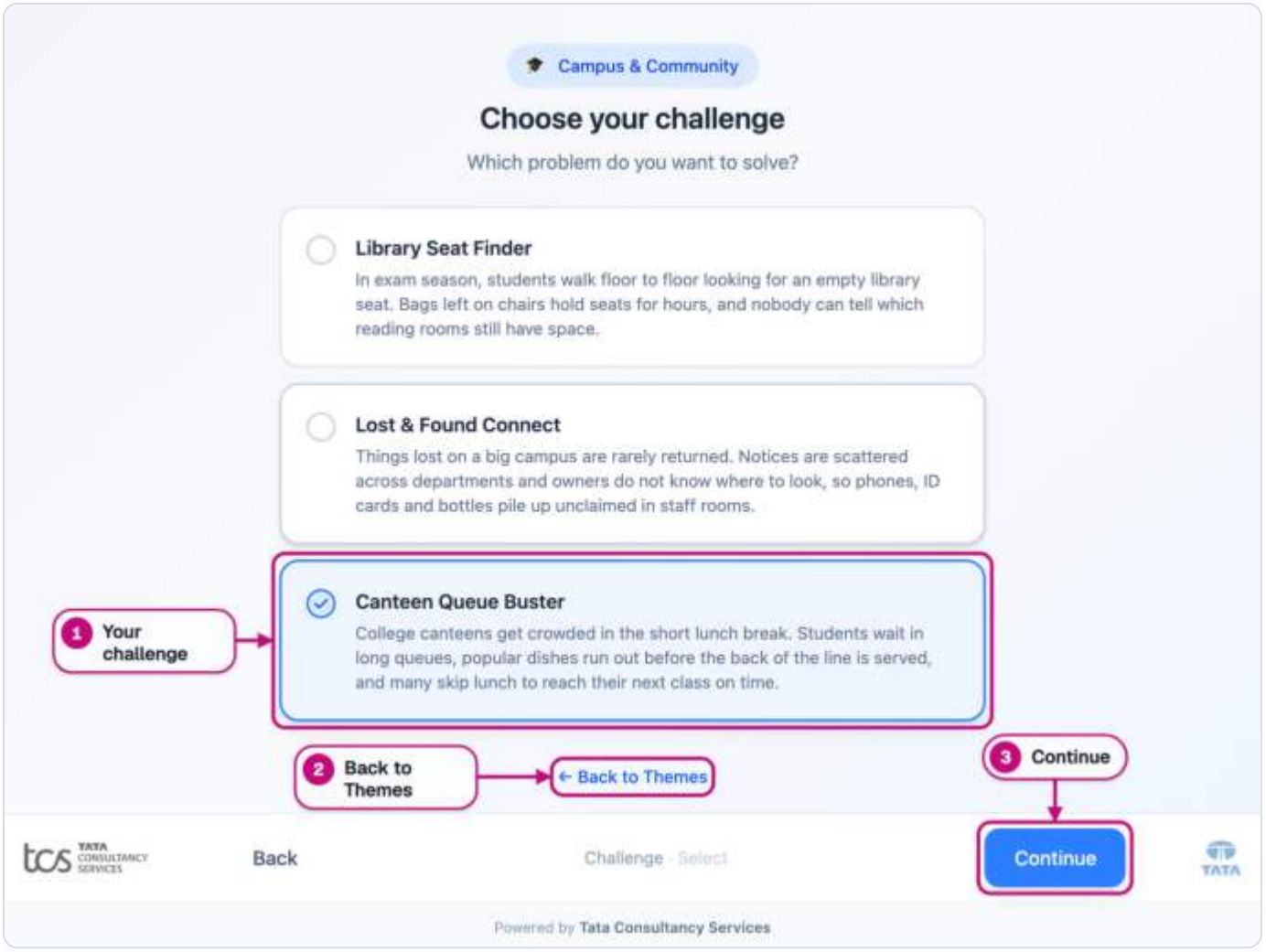
Select a theme



1 **Your theme** — Press the theme you care about. A tick shows your choice. Each theme has several challenges.

2 **Continue** — Shows the challenges in that theme.

Choose your challenge



1. **Your challenge** — Read each problem and press the one you want to solve.
2. **Back to Themes** — Changed your mind? Go back and choose another theme.
3. **Continue** — Opens Step 3.

Pick what you understand

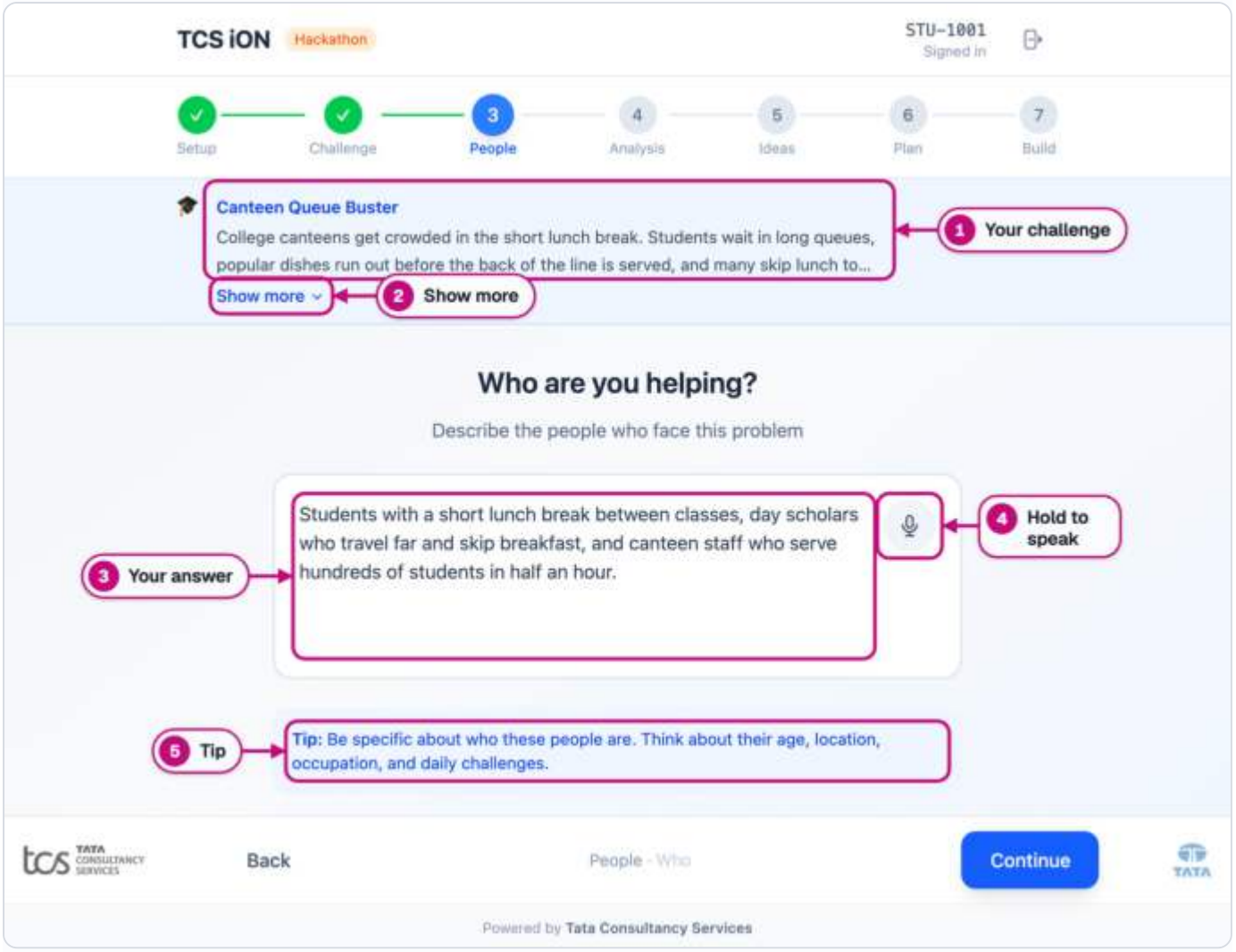
Choose the problem you know best. In the next step you describe the people it affects.

Step 3 of 7 · People

Say who has the problem, and what it is

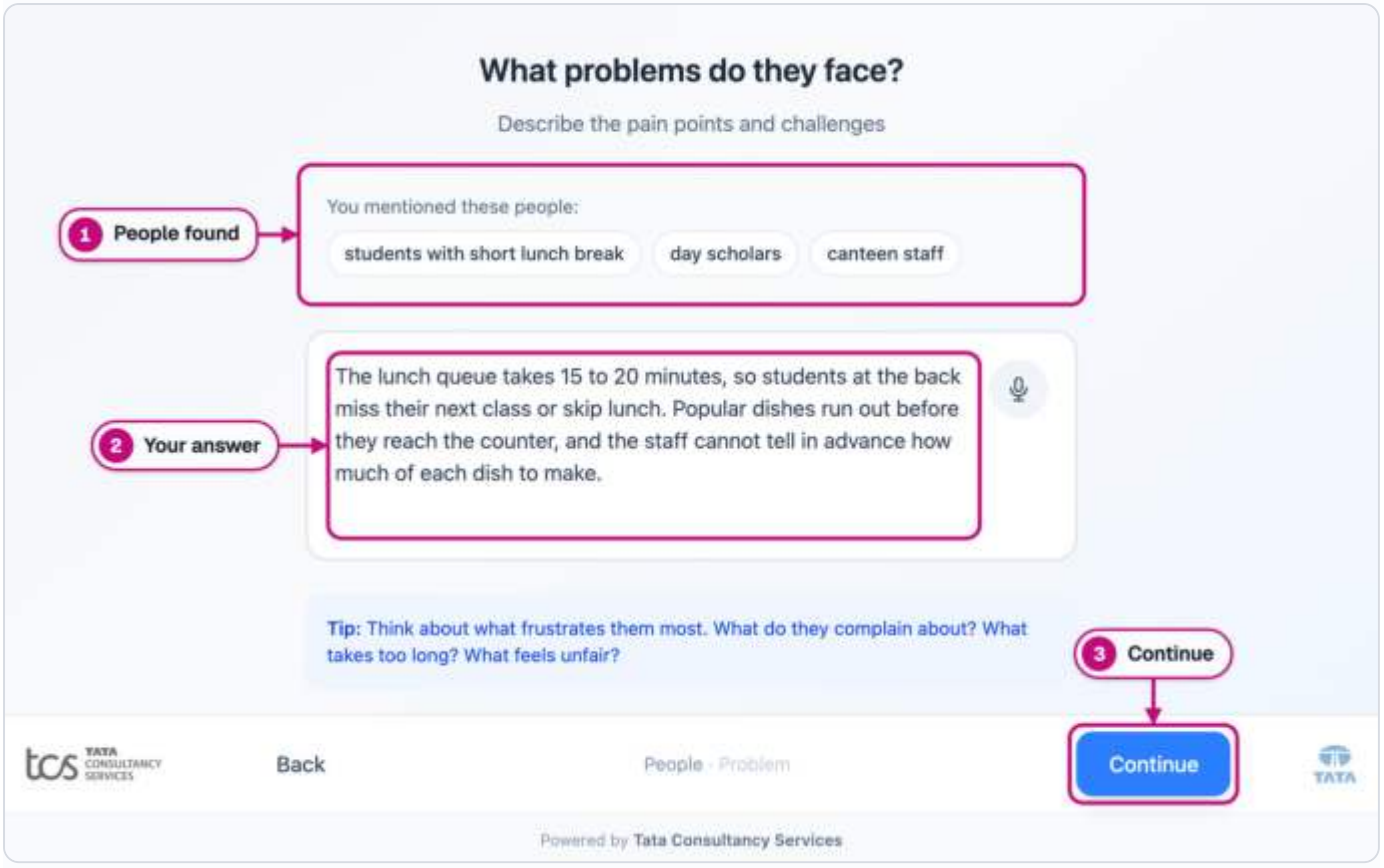
People · Who

Who are you helping?



1. **Your challenge** — Your challenge stays at the top from now on, so you never lose sight of the problem.
2. **Show more** — Opens the full description. Press **Show less** to close it.
3. **Your answer** — Describe the people: who they are, where they live, their age or work, and what their day is like.
4. **Hold to speak** — Hold this button and speak instead of typing. See **Handy features**.
5. **Tip** — A hint for a good answer.

What problems do they face?

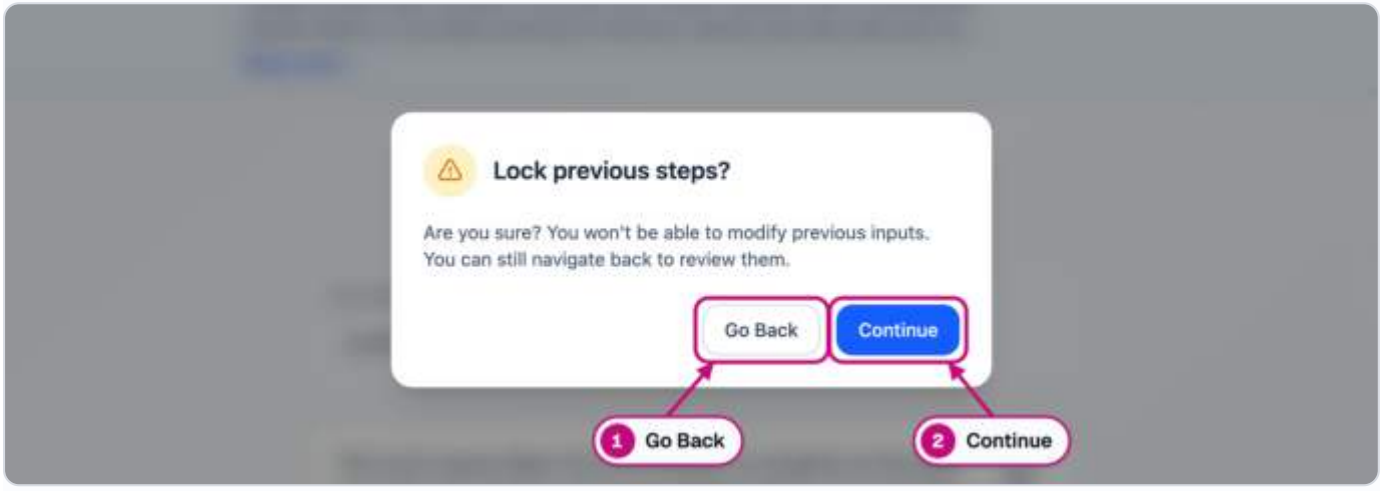


1. **People found** — Short names the AI picked out of your answer. You don't need to do anything with them.
2. **Your answer** — Describe what goes wrong for them: what takes too long, costs too much or feels unfair.
3. **Continue** — Asks you to lock your answers first — see the next picture.

Locking your answers

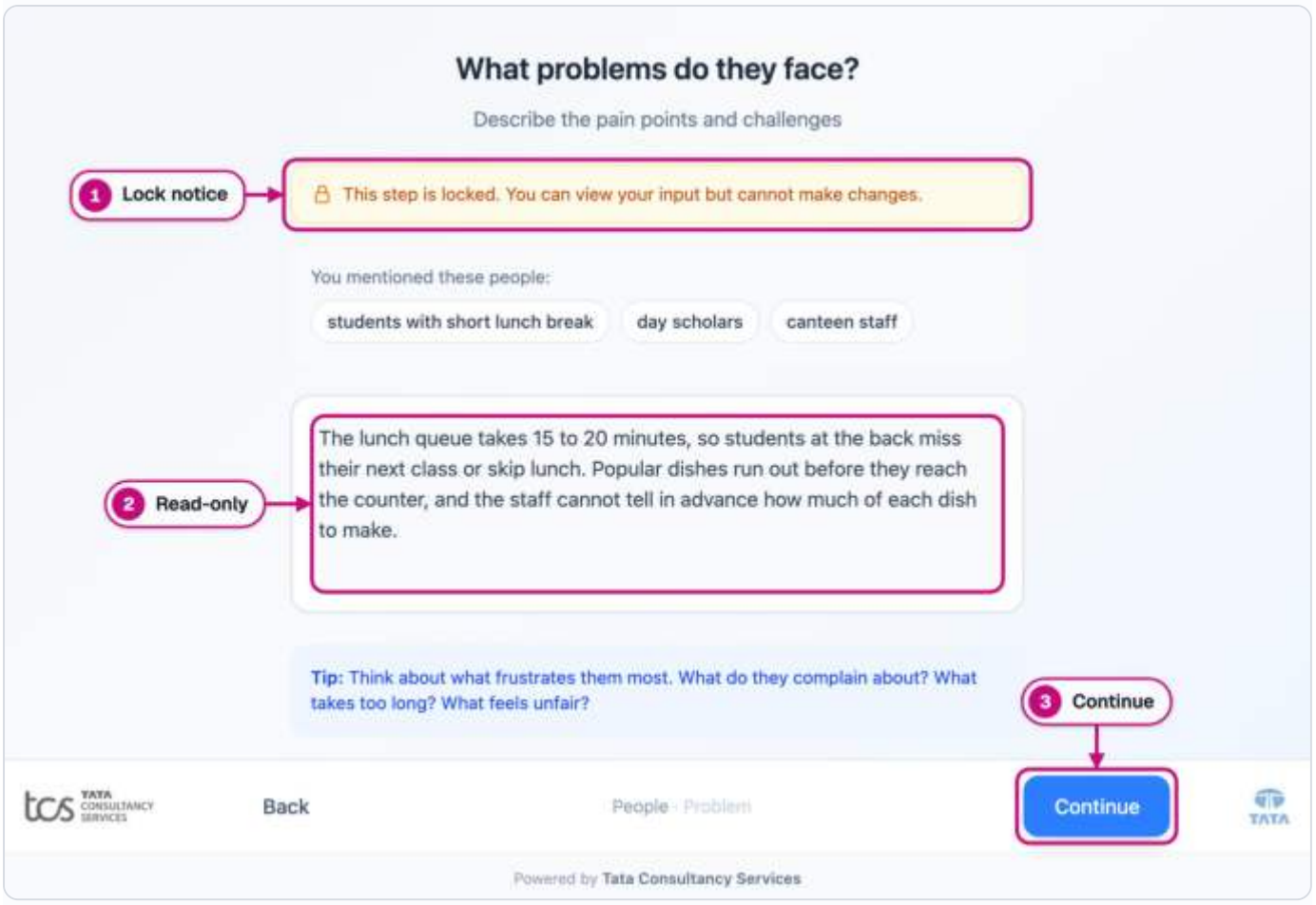
Four times, the platform asks you to lock what you have done so far: after **People · Problem**, after you pick a pain point, after the analysis, and after you confirm your idea.

Lock previous steps?



1. **Go Back** — Keeps the earlier screens open, so you can still edit them.
2. **Continue** — Locks the earlier screens and moves on. You can still go back and read them.

A locked screen

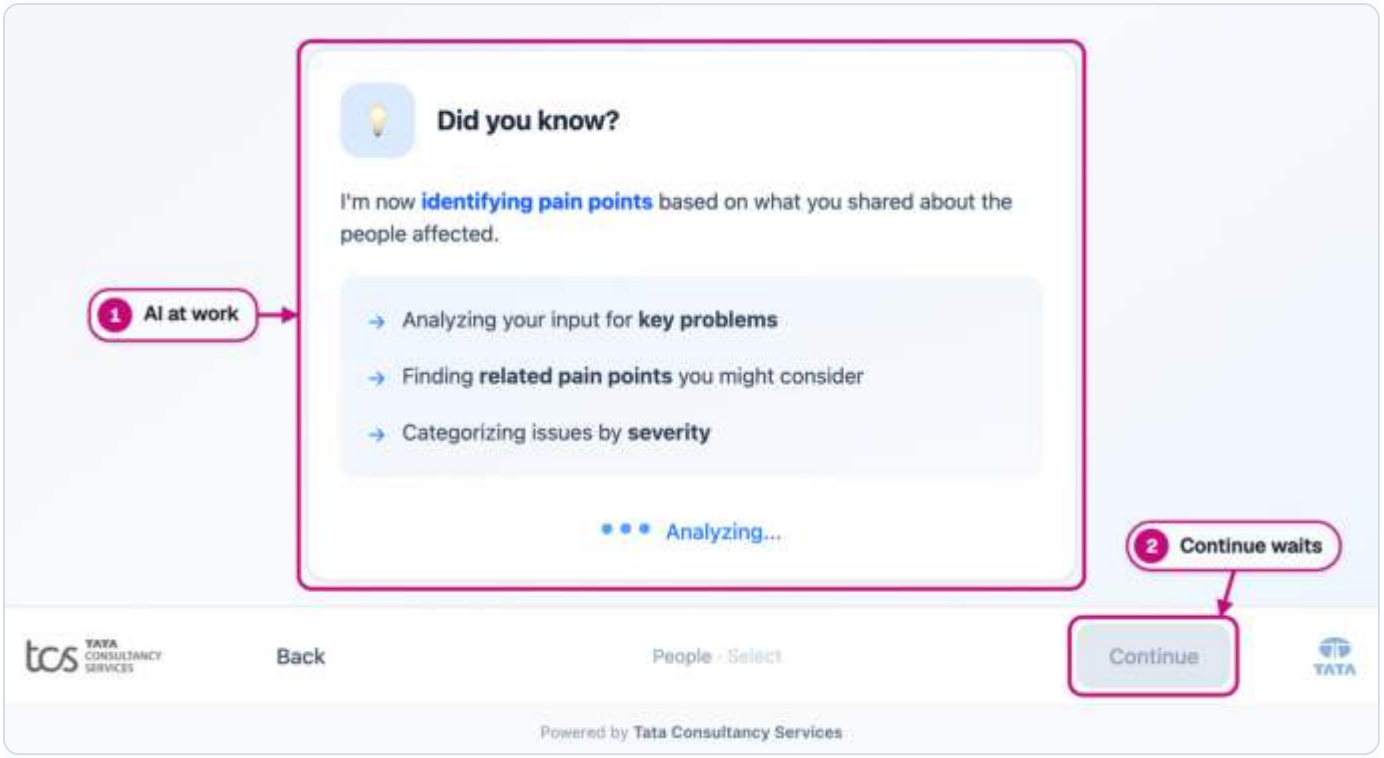


1. **Lock notice** — "This step is locked. You can view your input but cannot make changes."
2. **Read-only** — Your answer is shown but can't be edited.
3. **Continue** — Still works, so you can move forward again.

While the AI works

After some screens the AI prepares the next one. It usually takes a few seconds; the build plan can take about a minute.

The AI is preparing your pain points

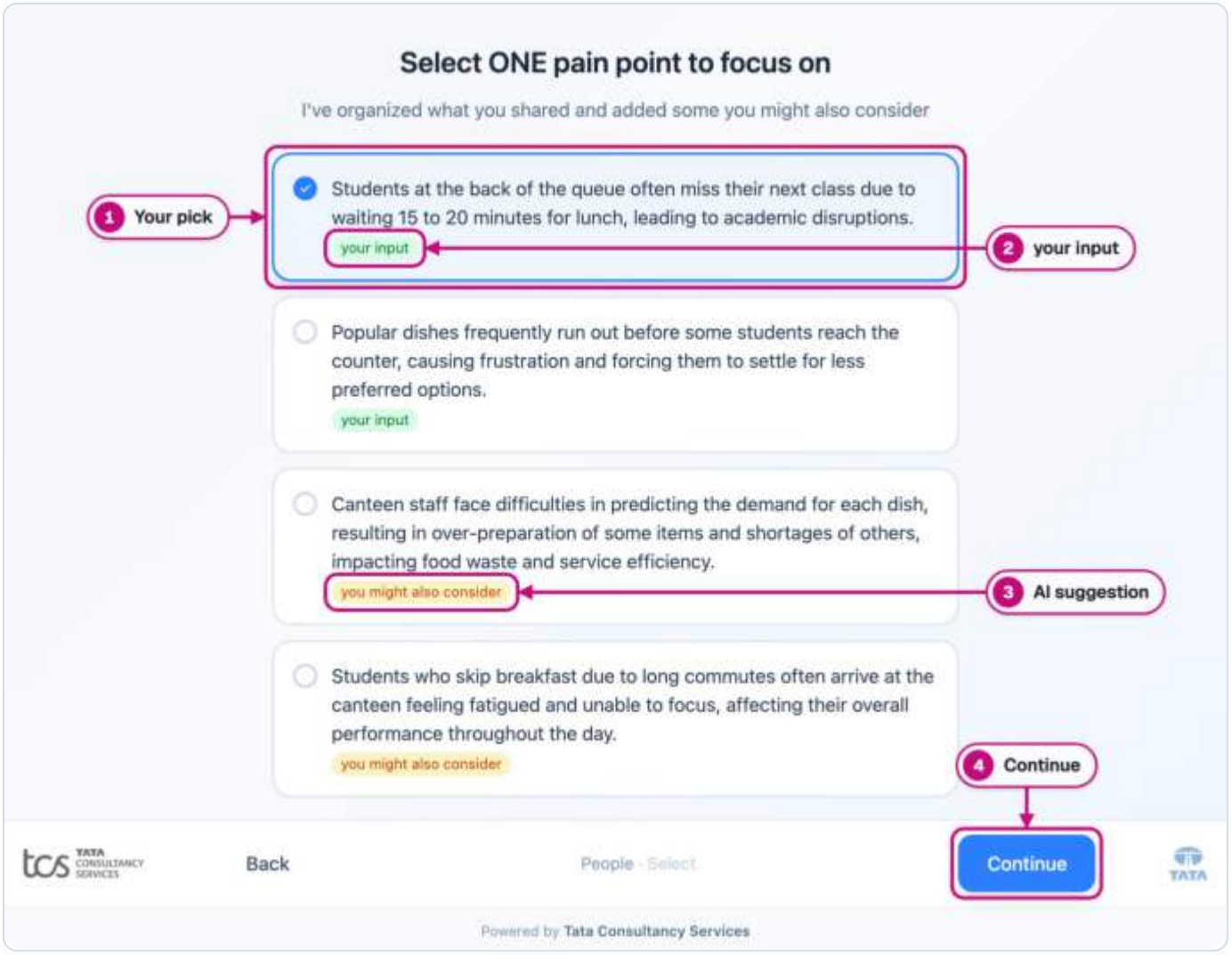


1. **AI at work** — Explains what the AI is doing. Read it while you wait.
2. **Continue waits** — Grey until the result is ready.

Wait for the result

Let the result appear before you press **Continue**, and don't refresh the page while the AI is working.

Select ONE pain point to focus on



1. **Your pick** — Press one pain point. The blue tick shows your choice.
2. **your input** — Written from what you typed.
3. **AI suggestion** — Extra pain points the AI suggests, tagged **you might also consider**. You can pick one of these too.
4. **Continue** — Locks your choice and opens Step 4.

Step 4 of 7 · Analysis

Find the root cause

The AI asks “Why?” five times about your pain point to find what is really causing it. There is nothing to type — read it through.

Analysis

Root Cause Analysis

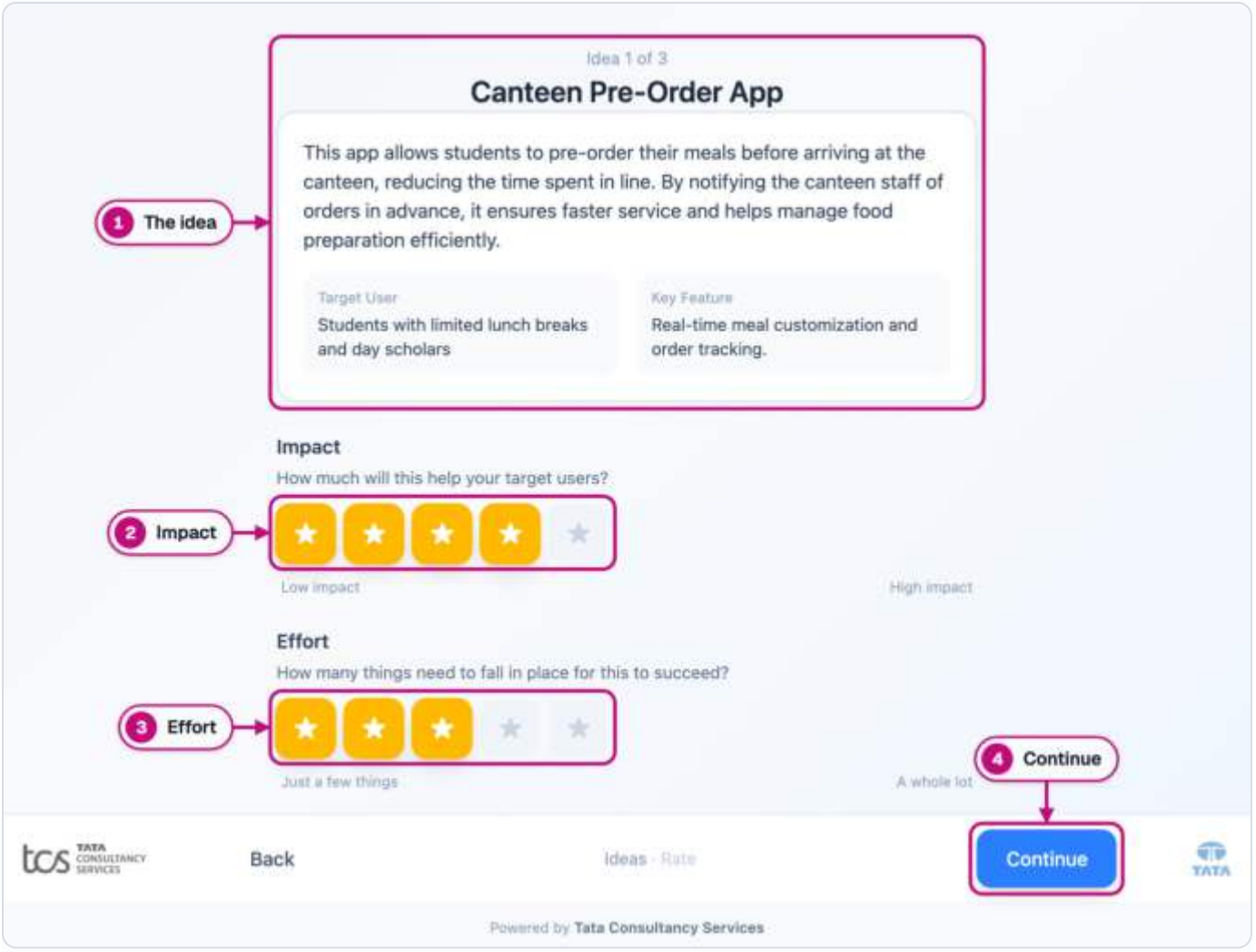


1. **Five whys** — Each “Why?” goes one level deeper into the problem.
2. **Root cause** — The real cause. Your idea should fix this.
3. **Try this at home** — Shows the prompt behind this analysis, so you can use the same method with any AI tool later.
4. **Continue** — Locks the analysis and opens Step 5.

Rate three ideas, then pick one

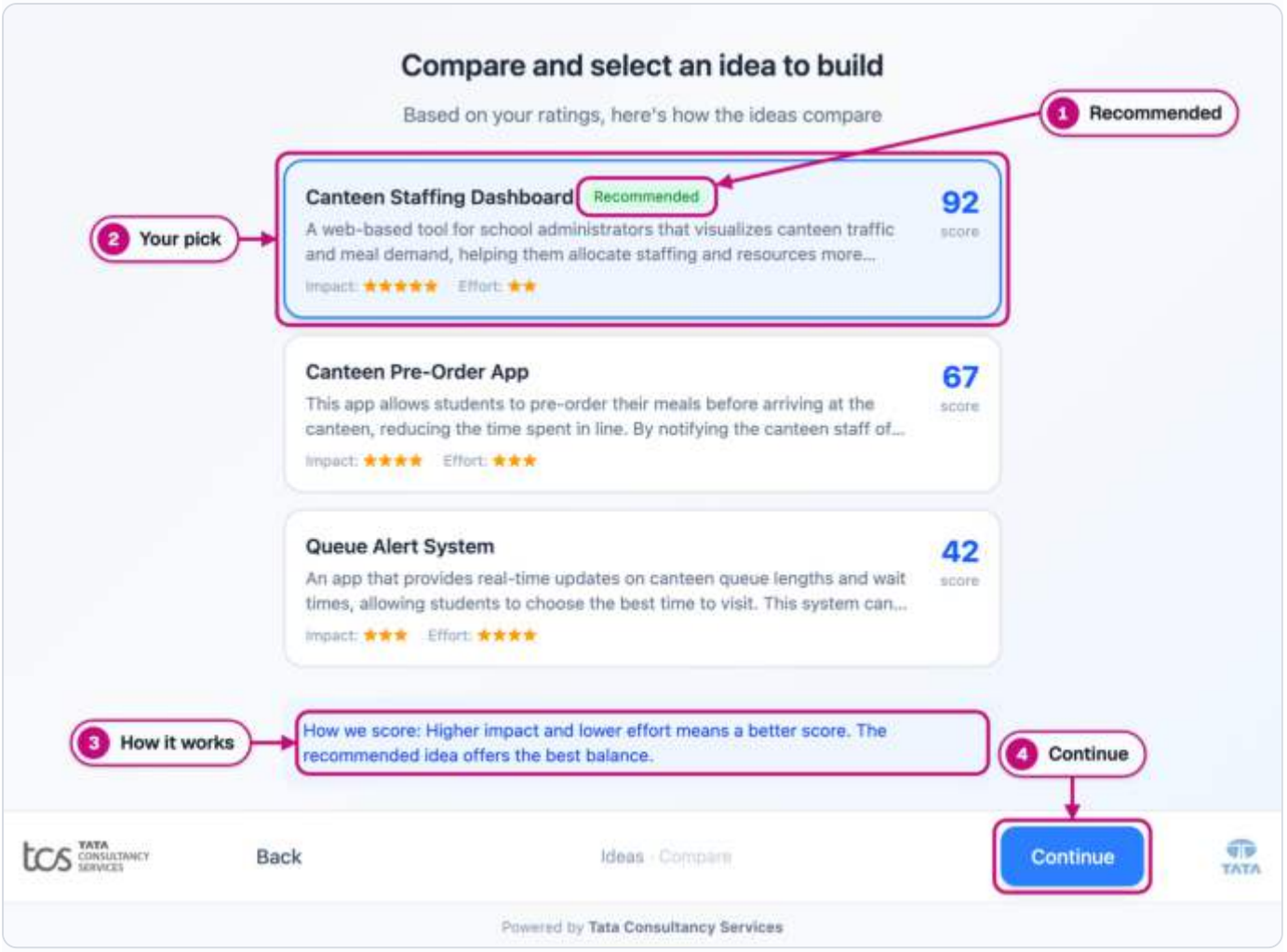
Ideas · Rate

Idea 1 of 3



1. **The idea** — An idea that tackles your root cause, who it is for, and its key feature.
2. **Impact** — How much would it help? One star is a little, five stars is a lot.
3. **Effort** — How much has to go right for it to work? One star is just a few things, five is a whole lot.
4. **Continue** — Opens the next idea. Rate all three.

Compare and select an idea to build

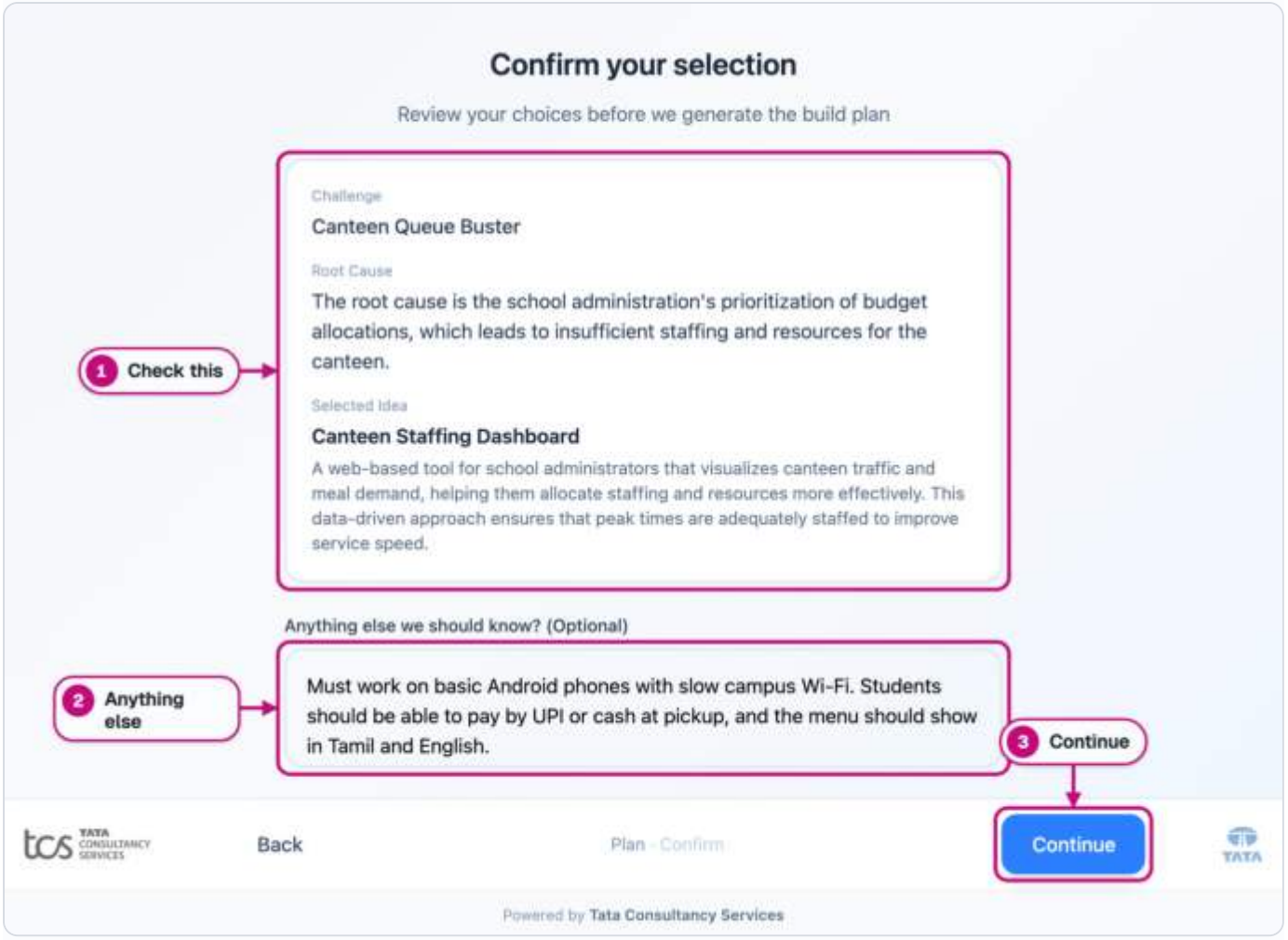


1. **Recommended** — The idea with the best mix of high impact and low effort, worked out from your own stars.
2. **Your pick** — Press the idea you want to build. It doesn't have to be the recommended one.
3. **How it works** — The number on each card comes only from your ratings.
4. **Continue** — Opens Step 6.

Confirm your idea and get your build plan

Plan · Confirm

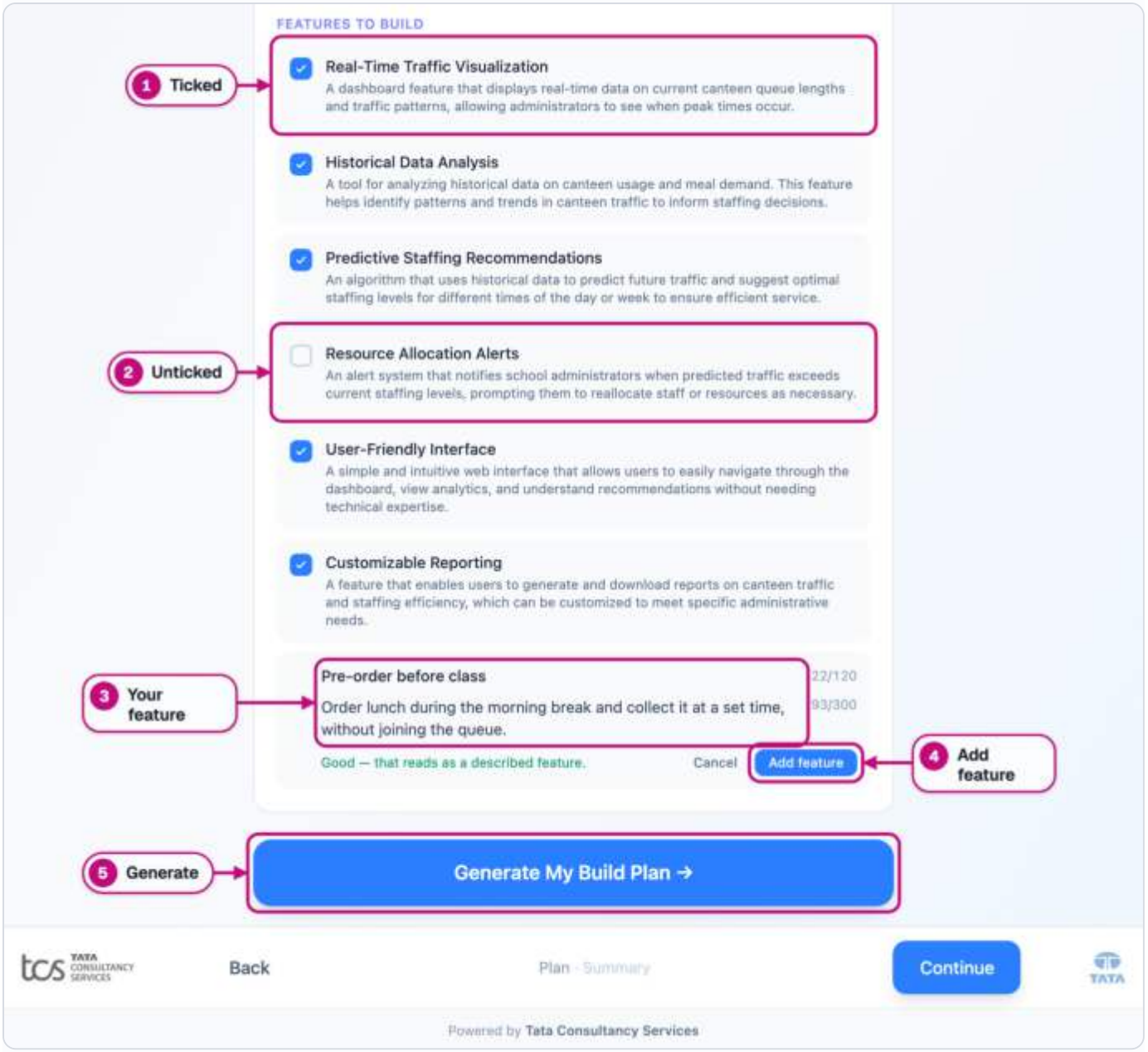
Confirm your selection



1. **Check this** — Your challenge, root cause and chosen idea. Check them.
2. **Anything else** — Optional. Add wishes or limits — the phones people use, languages, working without internet. They go into your plan.
3. **Continue** — Locks your idea.

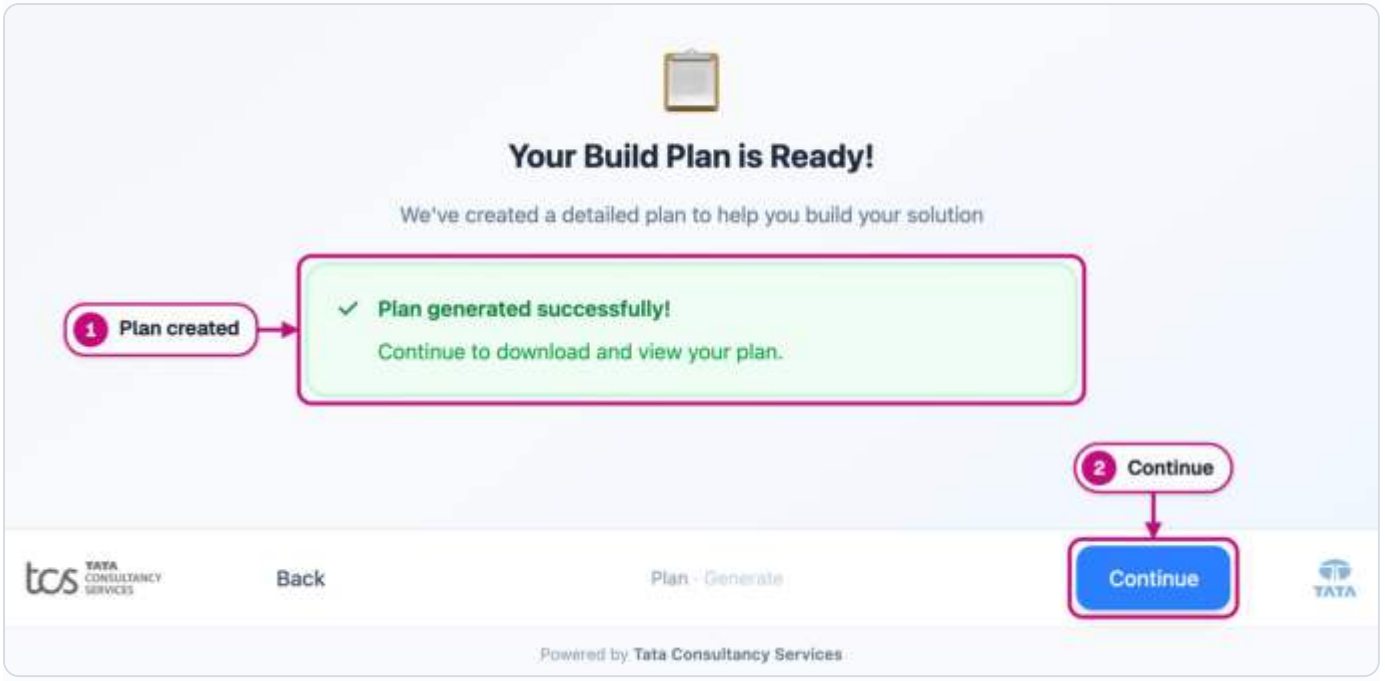
Next, the AI suggests features for your idea. The heading says **Your Build Plan is ready!**, but the plan is only created when you press **Generate My Build Plan**.

Features to Build



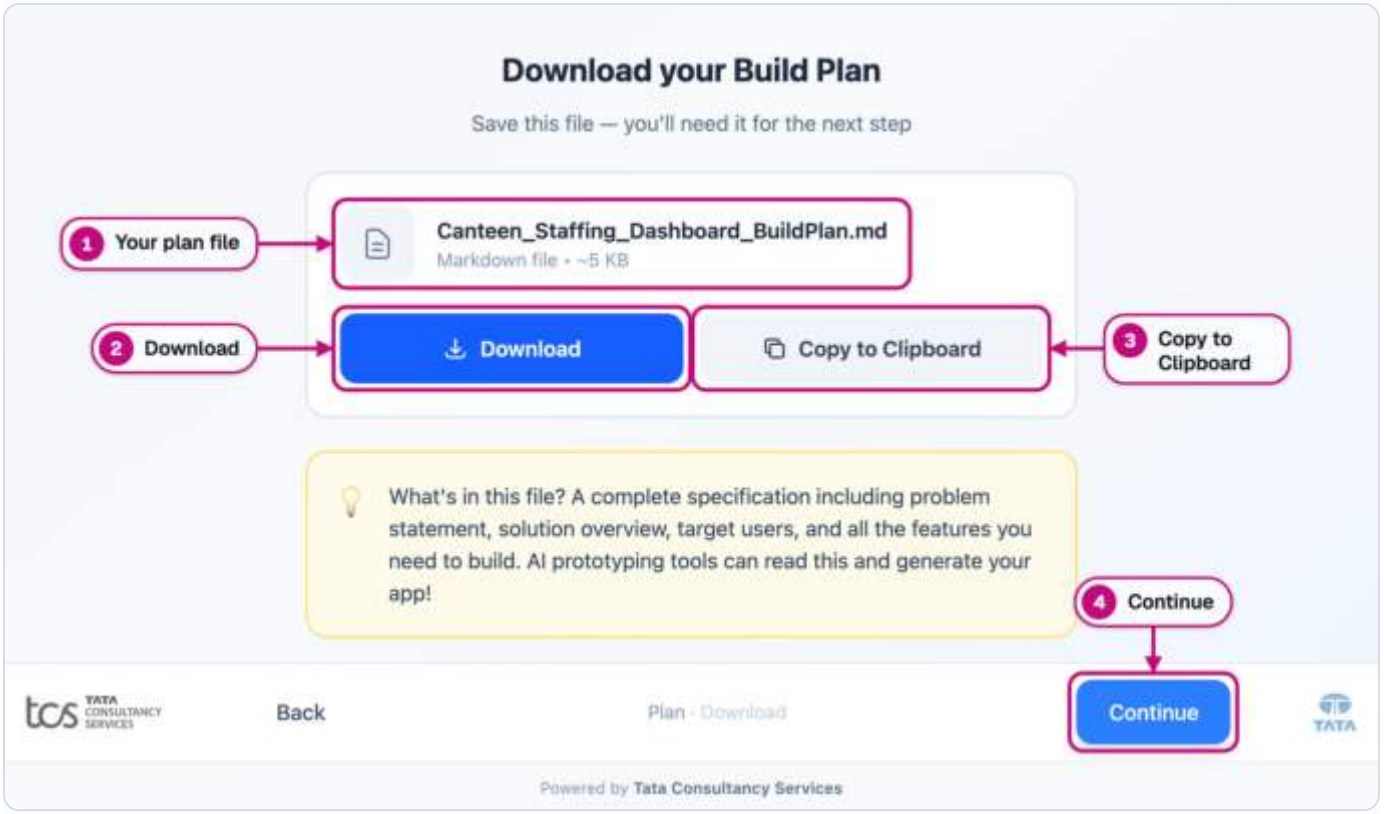
1. **Ticked** — A ticked feature goes into your plan. Press a feature to tick or untick it.
2. **Unticked** — An unticked feature is left out.
3. **Your feature** — Press **+ Add a feature** to add your own: a short name, and a sentence on what it does and who it is for. You can add two.
4. **Add feature** — Saves your feature to the list.
5. **Generate** — Creates your build plan from the ticked features. It takes about a minute.

Your build plan is created



1. **Plan created** — **Plan generated successfully!** means you are ready for the next screen.
2. **Continue** — Opens the download screen.

Download your Build Plan



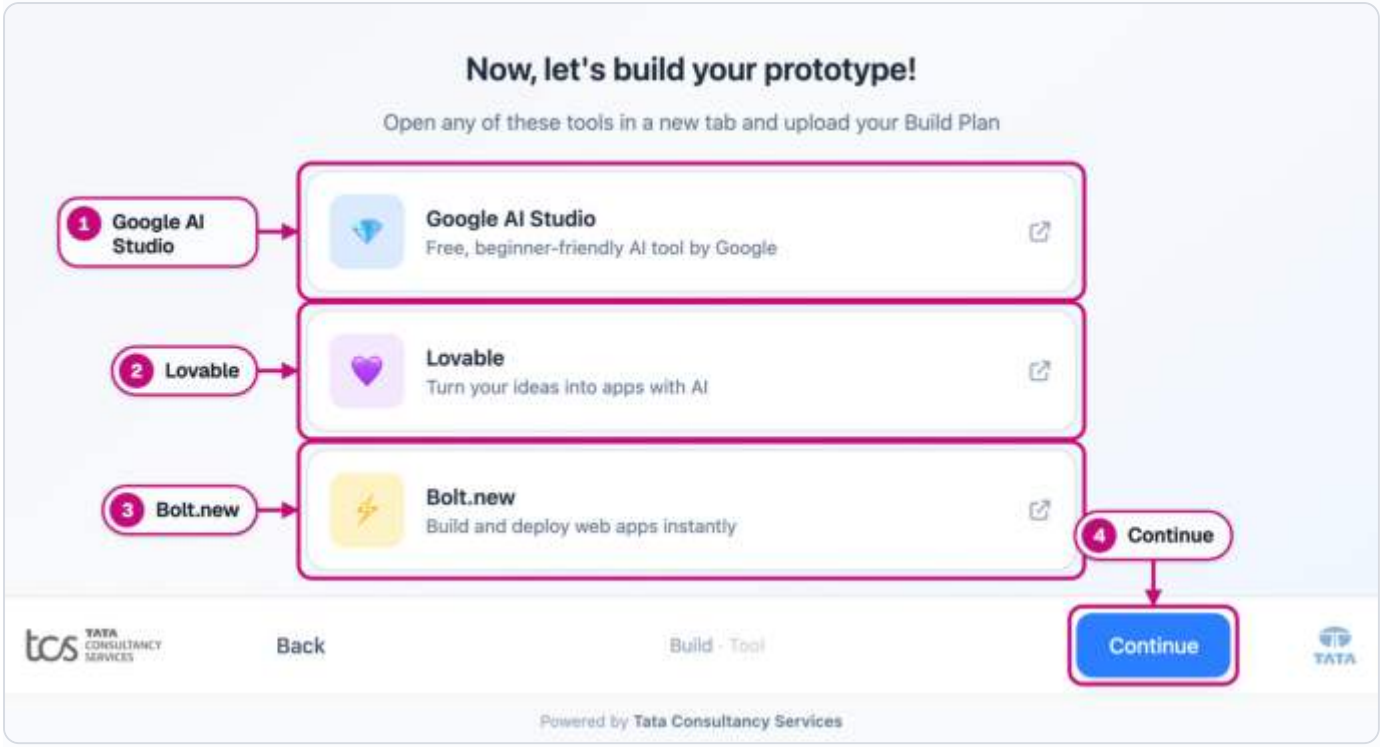
1. **Your plan file** — A text file (.md) named after your idea.
2. **Download** — Saves the file to your computer. Keep it for the building tool.
3. **Copy to Clipboard** — Copies the whole plan so you can paste it straight into the building tool — the quickest way.
4. **Continue** — Opens Step 7.

Step 7 of 7 · Build

Build your prototype and submit it

Build · Tool

Now, let's build your prototype!



1. **Google AI Studio** — Free, from Google. Sign in with your personal Google account.
2. **Lovable** — Builds a web app from your plan.
3. **Bolt.new** — Builds and runs a web app in your browser.
4. **Continue** — Opens the upload screen. Press it when your prototype is ready.

Pressing a tool opens it in a new browser tab. Keep the hackathon tab open — you come back to it to upload.

Build it in the tool

1. Sign in to the tool with your own personal account, such as your personal Gmail. No account yet? Sign up — it's free.
2. Start a new project or chat.
3. Give it your build plan: on **Plan · Download** press **Copy to Clipboard**, then paste into the tool's prompt box (Ctrl + V on Windows, Cmd + V on Mac). If the tool accepts files, you can attach the downloaded .md file instead.
4. Add one line, for example: `Build a working prototype of this app. Start with the main screen.`
5. Check the preview. Ask for one change at a time, for example `Make the Order now button green` or `Add a Tamil and English switch`.
6. If something breaks, paste the error message into the tool and ask it to fix it.
7. When it works, take two or three screenshots (Windows + Shift + S on Windows, Cmd + Shift + 4 on Mac), or record a short screen video under 50 MB.

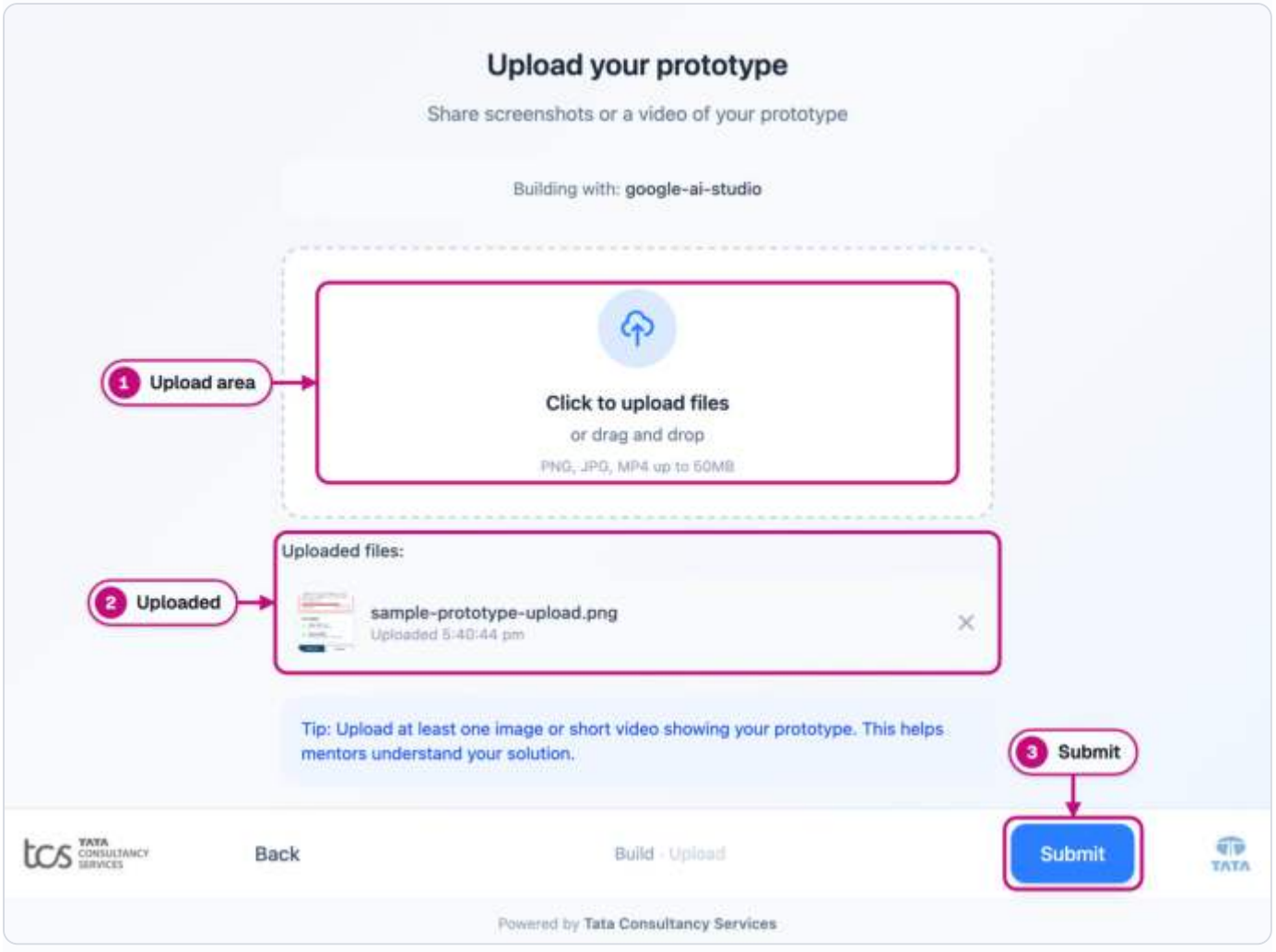
Tool	Website	Sign in with	Good to know
Google AI Studio	`aistudio.google.com`	Your personal Google account	Free. Paste your plan and ask it to build the app.
Lovable	`lovable.dev`	Personal email, Google or GitHub	The free plan has a daily limit on messages.
Bolt.new	`bolt.new`	Personal email, Google or GitHub	The free plan has a usage limit.

Any tool is fine

You don't have to use these three. Use any tool you are comfortable with, as long as you finish within the 2 hours and upload screenshots or a video of what you built. If a free plan runs out, paste the same plan into another tool.

`Build · Upload`

Upload your prototype



1. **Upload area** — Click to choose files, or drag them here: PNG or JPG screenshots, or an MP4 video, up to 50 MB each. GIF, WEBM and MOV work too.
2. **Uploaded** — Each file appears here once it has uploaded. Add as many as you need.
3. **Submit** — Sends your work to the judges. Press it once.

iPhone photos

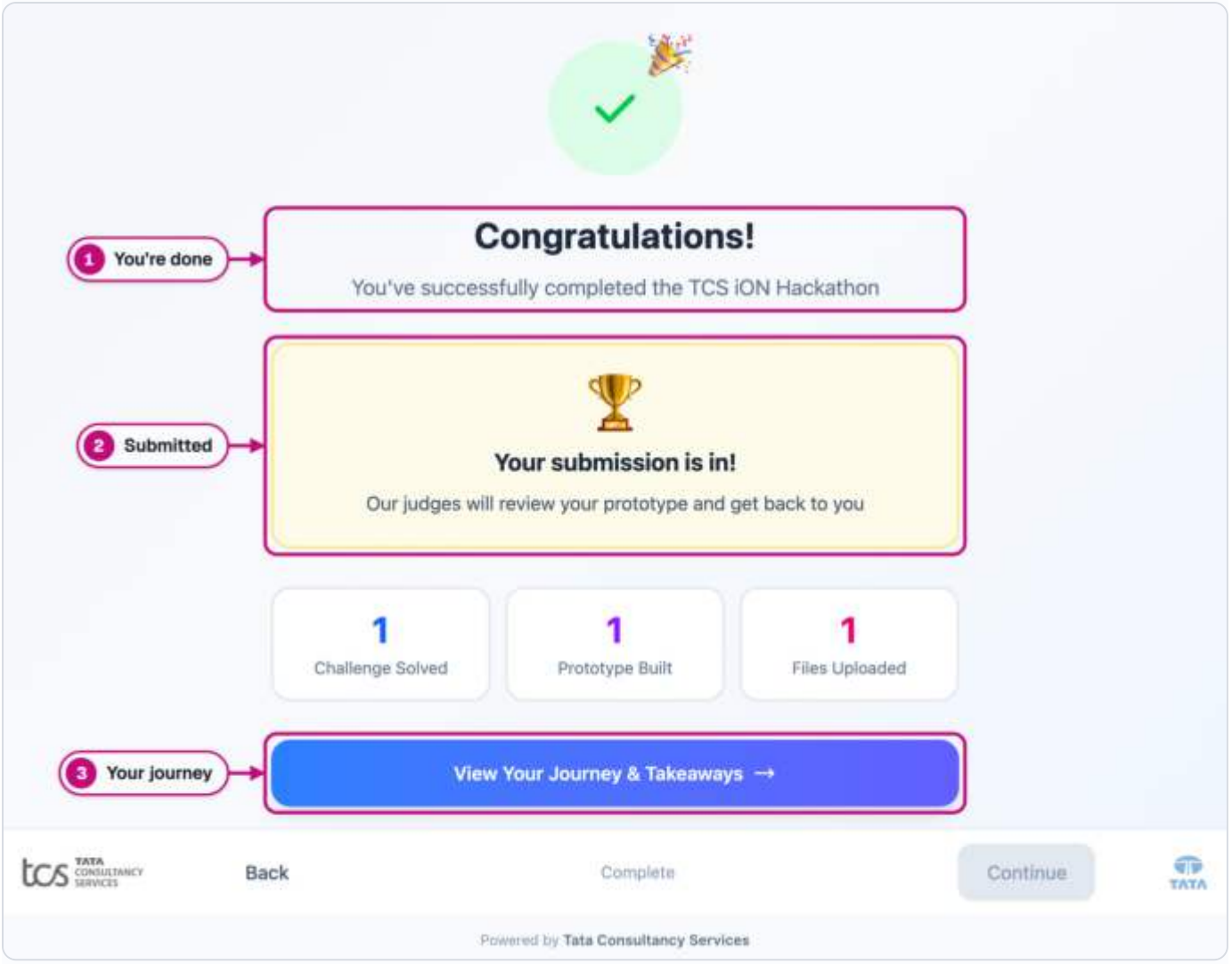
iPhone photos (HEIC) don't upload. Use screenshots, or set iPhone **Settings › Camera › Formats** to **Most Compatible**.

Finish

You’re done

Complete

Congratulations!



1 **You’re done** — Your work has been submitted.

2 **Submitted** — The judges review your prototype. Your coordinator shares the results.

3 **Your journey** — A summary of what you did today, and prompts you can reuse with any AI tool.

Finished means finished

Once you see **Congratulations!**, you can close the tab. Don’t press **Back** on this screen.

No Congratulations after Submit?

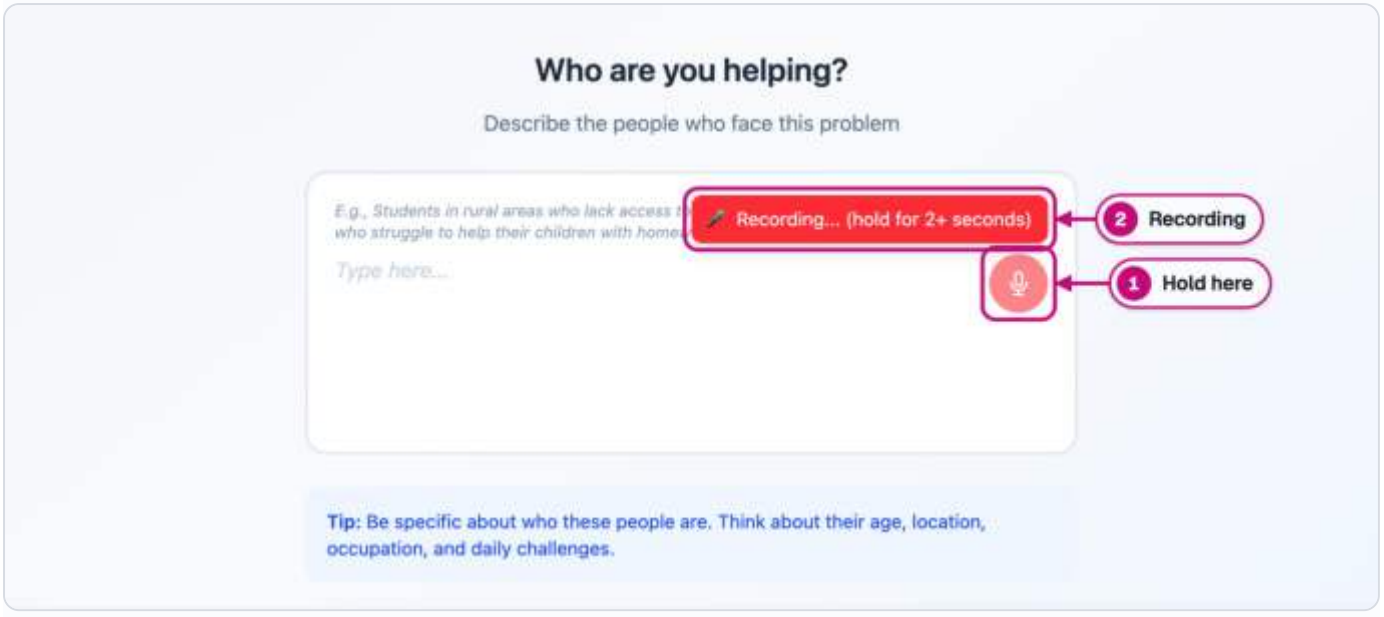
Wait a few seconds, then refresh the page. Your work is saved, and the Congratulations screen appears.

Handy features

Speak instead of typing

On **People · Who** and **People · Problem**, hold the microphone button, speak, and let go to stop. Hold it for at least two seconds; a recording stops by itself after 30 seconds. Your words are added to the box — read them before you continue. The first time, your browser asks to use the microphone: choose **Allow**.

Recording with the microphone

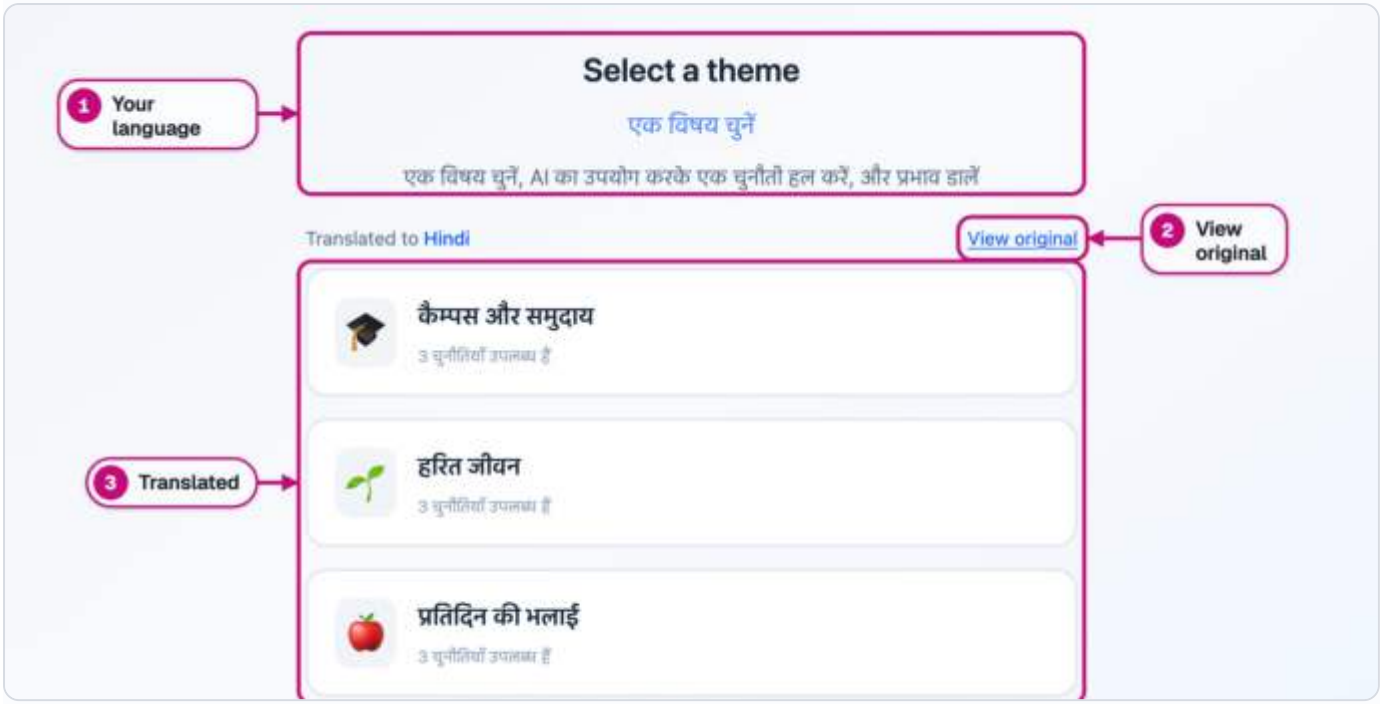


1. **Hold here** — Hold the button while you speak. It turns red while recording.
2. **Recording** — Shows that the platform is listening.

Use the platform in your language

Headings show English with your language underneath, and the AI's results are translated. Buttons stay in English. Your build plan file is in English, which the building tools understand best. You can type or speak in your own language.

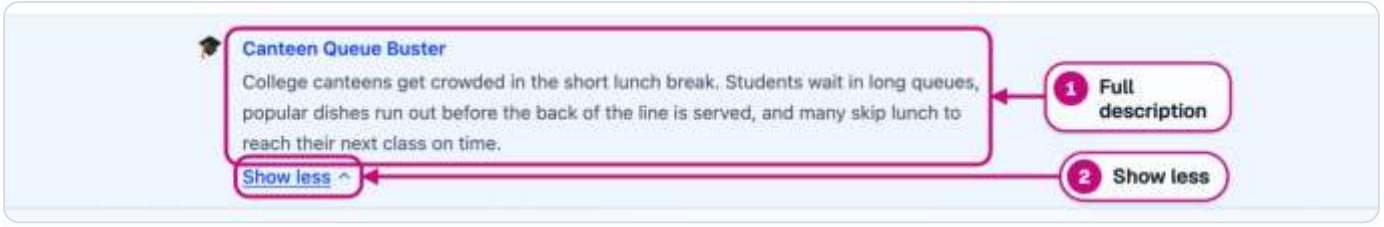
The theme screen in Hindi



1. **Your language** — The English heading, with your language underneath.
2. **View original** — Shows the English text. Press it again to switch back.
3. **Translated** — AI and challenge text in your language.

See the whole challenge

The challenge banner, opened



1. **Full description** — The full challenge description.
2. **Show less** — Closes it again. The banner stays open or closed as you move between screens.

Your work is saved

Every time you press **Continue** or **Back**. Text you type is saved when you press **Continue**, so press it before you close the browser.

Coming back after a break

Open the link again. You may still be signed in; if not, sign in with the same event code and student ID and you pick up where you stopped. A sign-in lasts up to 4 hours, or until the event ends.

If something goes wrong

Sign-in messages

Message on screen	Ref	What to do
We couldn't find that event code. Please check it with your coordinator.	`IF-01`	Check the code for typing mistakes. Ask your coordinator for the right code.
This event hasn't opened yet. It starts on …	`IF-02`	Wait until the start time shown.
This event has closed.	`IF-03`	The time window is over. Speak to your coordinator.
This event isn't accepting sign-ins right now.	`IF-04`	Speak to your coordinator.
Your Student ID isn't registered for this event. Please check with your coordinator.	`IF-05`	Check your ID for spaces and missing zeros. Your coordinator can add you.
Your access has been paused. Please contact your coordinator.	`IF-06`	Speak to your coordinator.
Too many attempts. Please wait a minute and try again.	`IF-07`	Wait one minute, then try once more, carefully.
We're having trouble reaching the system. Please try again in a moment.	`IF-08`	Wait a moment and try again.
This event has closed. Your work has been saved.	`IF-09`	The event ended while you were working. Your work is saved.
Please enter your Student ID exactly as it appears on iON, with no spaces.	—	Remove any spaces and type the ID exactly.
Please check the event code — letters, numbers, hyphens and underscores only.	—	Remove any other characters.
We couldn't reach the system. Please check your connection and try again.	—	Check your internet, then try again.
Your session has ended. Please sign in again.	—	Sign in again. You carry on where you stopped.

Other problems

What you see	What to do
A screen titled **… Failed** with a **Try Again** button	Press **Try Again**. If it fails again, wait a minute, try once more, then tell your coordinator.
The AI worker is busy. Please try again in a moment.	Wait a minute, then press **Try Again**.
Continue stays grey	Answer the screen first: type something, press a card, or rate both Impact and Effort.
A file won't upload, or you see "… is a .heic file"	Upload PNG or JPG screenshots. On iPhone, set **Settings › Camera › Formats** to **Most Compatible**.
Some files exceed the 50MB limit and were not added.	Upload a shorter video, or screenshots instead.
The microphone doesn't work	Allow the microphone in your browser and hold the button for at least two seconds — or type instead.
The screen looks stuck	Refresh the page. Your saved work comes back.

Still stuck?

Tell your coordinator your student ID and, if you see one, the reference code — for example `IF-05`.